

Word family: **fire / fires / fired / firing / fiery / firefighter / fireproof**

Base word: fire

Part of speech: mainly **noun** and **verb**

Related forms:

- * **fire** (n.) — 火；火災；射擊；怒火；猛烈批評
- * **fire** (v.) — 開火；發射；解僱；激發；快速提出
- * **fired** (adj./participle) — 被解僱的；已發射的
- * **firing** (n./gerund) — 射擊；解僱；點火 / 啟動
- * **fiery** (adj.) — 火熱的；猛烈的；暴躁的
- * **firefighter** (n.) — 消防員
- * **fireproof** (adj./v.) — 防火的；使防火
- * **fireplace** (n.) — 壁爐
- * **firework** (n.) — 煙花
- * **wildfire** (n.) — 山火；野火
- * **bonfire** (n.) — 篝火；大型露天火堆

Useful expressions / extensions:

- * **catch fire**
- * **set fire to**
- * **on fire**
- * **put out a fire**
- * **fight a fire**
- * **open fire**
- * **come under fire**
- * **fire a gun**
- * **fire someone**
- * **get fired**
- * **fire questions at someone**
- * **fire off an email**
- * **fire up**
- * **under fire**
- * **play with fire**
- * **add fuel to the fire**
- * **put out fires**
- * **like wildfire**
- * **fire in your belly**
- * **fire someone up**

Meaning in this passage

> Instead of constantly **putting out fires**, I started planning ahead and thinking more clearly.

Here, **putting out fires** is figurative.

It means:

dealing with urgent problems one after another instead of preventing them through planning
— 不停救火；不斷處理突發問題

The speaker used to wait until problems became urgent, then react at the last minute.

中文翻譯：

與其不停地到處救火 / 處理突發問題，我開始懂得提前規劃。

So here:

put out fires = 比喻不停處理突然出現、需要立即解決的問題

1. **fire (火)** — 火；火焰

The core literal noun sense.

Practice 1

> We sat around the **fire**.

我們圍着**火堆**坐。

Practice 2

> The **fire** kept us warm.

火令我們保持溫暖。

Practice 3

> The wood caught **fire** quickly.

木材很快**着火**。

MCQ-ready definition:

fire = 燃燒時產生的火焰、熱和光

2. **fire (火災) — 火災**

Practice 1

> A **fire** broke out in the kitchen.

廚房發生了**火災**。

Practice 2

> The building was damaged by **fire**.

大樓受到**火災**破壞。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****fire = 不受控制、可能造成損害的燃燒事故****

3. **catch fire — 着火**

Practice 1

> The curtains **caught fire**.

窗簾**着火了**。

Practice 2

> Dry grass can **catch fire** easily.

乾草很容易**着火**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****catch fire = 開始燃燒****

4. **be on fire — 正在燃燒 ; 着火**

Practice 1

> The car was **on fire**.

汽車**著火了**。

Practice 2

> Part of the building was **on fire**.

大樓的一部分**正在燃燒**。

MCQ-ready definition:

be on fire = 正在燃燒

5. **set fire to something — 放火燒某物；點燃某物**

Practice 1

> Someone **set fire to** the rubbish.

有人**放火燒**垃圾。

Practice 2

> The sparks **set fire to** the dry leaves.

火花**點燃了**乾葉。

MCQ-ready definition:

set fire to X = 令 X 開始燃燒，尤其是故意點火

6. **put out a fire — 滅火**

This is the literal source of the metaphor in your passage.

Practice 1

> Firefighters **put out the fire**.

消防員把火**撲滅了**。

Practice 2

> Use water only if it is safe to **put out the fire**.

只有在安全情況下才用水**滅火**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****put out a fire = 令火停止燃燒****

7. ****fight a fire — 救火；撲救火災****

Practice 1

> Firefighters worked all night to ****fight the fire****.

消防員整晚****撲救火災****。

Practice 2

> Several crews were sent to ****fight the fire****.

數支隊伍被派去****救火****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****fight a fire = 採取行動控制和撲滅火災****

8. ****fire (figurative : 問題 / 危機) — 緊急問題；危機****

This is the branch behind your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> I was constantly ****putting out fires****.

我以前總是在****不停救火 / 處理突發問題****。

Practice 2

> The manager spent the whole day ****putting out fires****.

經理整天都在****處理一個又一個突發問題****。

Practice 3

> Better planning means fewer ****fires to put out****.

更好的規劃意味著少一些需要立即處理的**突發危機**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****fire = figurative: 突然出現、需要立即處理的問題或危機****

9. ****put out fires — 不停處理突發問題****

Practice 1

> Instead of ****putting out fires****, we should prevent problems early.

與其不停****救火****，我們應該提早預防問題。

Practice 2

> Poor organisation leaves managers constantly ****putting out fires****.

組織不善令經理經常要****處理突發問題****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****put out fires = 被動地一再處理已經變得緊急的問題****

10. ****fire (武器：射擊 / 火力) — 射擊；炮火；火力****

A major distinct noun sense.

Practice 1

> The soldiers came under heavy ****fire****.

士兵遭到猛烈****炮火 / 射擊****。

Practice 2

> They returned ****fire****.

他們****還擊****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****fire = 由槍械或其他武器造成的射擊或火力****

11. **open fire — 開火**

Practice 1

> The soldiers were ordered not to **open fire**.

士兵被命令不得**開火**。

Practice 2

> Someone suddenly **opened fire**.

有人突然**開槍**。

MCQ-ready definition:

open fire = 開始用槍械射擊

12. **come under fire — 遭到射擊**

Literal sense first.

Practice 1

> The vehicle **came under fire**.

車輛**遭到射擊**。

Practice 2

> The troops **came under heavy fire**.

部隊**遭受猛烈炮火**。

MCQ-ready definition:

come under fire = 遭受武器射擊

13. **come under fire (figurative) — 遭到猛烈批評**

A major figurative extension.

Practice 1

> The company **came under fire** for poor service.

公司因服務欠佳而**受到猛烈批評**。

Practice 2

> He **came under fire** after the decision.

作出那個決定後，他**備受批評**。

MCQ-ready definition:

come under fire = figurative: 遭到強烈、公開的批評或攻擊

14. **under fire** — 受到攻擊 / 批評

Practice 1

> The policy is **under fire** from several groups.

這項政策受到多個團體**猛烈批評**。

Practice 2

> She remained calm **under fire**.

她在**備受批評 / 壓力之下**仍保持冷靜。

MCQ-ready definition:

under fire = 正遭受射擊，或比喻正受到猛烈批評

15. **fire a gun / weapon** — 開槍；發射武器

Verb sense.

Practice 1

> He **fired the gun** into the air.

他向空中**開槍**。

Practice 2

> The weapon can **fire** several rounds quickly.

這件武器可以快速**發射**多發子彈。

MCQ-ready definition:

fire a weapon = 令槍械或武器發射子彈、炮彈等

16. **fire a shot / bullet / missile** — 發射子彈 / 導彈

Practice 1

> The soldier **fired** a warning shot.

士兵**鳴槍警告**。

Practice 2

> The system **fired** a missile.

系統**發射**了一枚導彈。

MCQ-ready definition:

fire X = 把子彈、炮彈、導彈等發射出去

17. **fire someone** — 解僱某人

A major modern verb sense.

Practice 1

> The company **fired him** for repeated lateness.

公司因他多次遲到而**解僱了他**。

Practice 2

> She was afraid her boss would **fire her**.

她擔心老闆會**炒她魷魚 / 解僱她**。

MCQ-ready definition:

****fire someone = 終止某人的僱傭關係，令其失去工作****

18. ****get fired / be fired — 被解僱；被炒魷魚****

Practice 1

> He ****got fired**** last week.

他上星期****被解僱了****。

Practice 2

> She was ****fired from her job****.

她****被公司解僱****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****get/be fired = 被僱主終止工作****

19. ****firing (解僱) — 解僱行為****

Practice 1

> The sudden ****firing**** shocked the staff.

這次突然的****解僱****令員工震驚。

Practice 2

> The company defended the ****firing****.

公司為這次****解僱決定****辯護。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firing = 解僱某人的行為****

20. ****fire questions at someone — 連珠炮般向某人提問****

A vivid figurative use.

Practice 1

> Reporters **fired questions at** the speaker.

記者向講者**連珠炮般發問**。

Practice 2

> The interviewer **fired question after question at me**.

面試官向我**接連不斷地發問**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****fire questions at someone = 快速、接連地向某人提出很多問題****

21. ****fire off something — 快速發出 / 寫出****

A common phrasal verb.

Practice 1

> I **fired off an email** before leaving.

我離開前**迅速發了一封電郵**。

Practice 2

> She **fired off a quick reply**.

她**迅速回覆了一句**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****fire off X = 很快、往往沒有花太多時間地發送或說出 X****

22. ****fire back — 迅速反駁；回擊****

Practice 1

> She **fired back** with an angry reply.

她立即**憤怒反駁**。

Practice 2

> He **fi**red back at his critics**.**

他向批評者**迅速回擊**。

MCQ-ready definition:

fire back = 迅速而強烈地回應、反駁或還擊

23. **fire up** (點燃 ; 啟動) — 點燃 ; 開動

Practice 1

> He **fi**red up the engine**.**

他**啟動了引擎**。

Practice 2

> Let's **fi**re up the barbecue**.**

我們**點起燒烤爐**吧。

MCQ-ready definition:

fire up something = 點燃、啟動或使機器開始運作

24. **fire up** someone — 激發 ; 令興奮起來

Figurative.

Practice 1

> The speech **fi**red up the crowd**.**

演講令群眾**情緒高漲**。

Practice 2

> Competition really **fi**res him up**.**

競爭真的會**激發他的鬥志**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****fire someone up = 令某人變得充滿熱情、鬥志或興奮****

25. ****be fired up — 充滿鬥志；十分興奮****

Practice 1

> The team was ****fired up**** before the match.

球隊賽前****鬥志高昂****。

Practice 2

> She was really ****fired up**** about the new idea.

她對新想法****非常興奮和投入****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****be fired up = 情緒高昂、充滿動力或熱情****

26. ****fire someone's imagination — 激發想像力****

Practice 1

> The story ****fired his imagination****.

那個故事****激發了他的想像力****。

Practice 2

> Space travel has long ****fired the public imagination****.

太空旅行長久以來一直****激發大眾想像****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****fire someone's imagination = 強烈激發某人的想像、興趣或創意****

27. ****fire in your belly — 鬥志；強烈動力****

Idiomatic.

Practice 1

> She still has plenty of **fire in her belly**.

她仍然很有**鬥志**。

Practice 2

> You need some **fire in your belly** to succeed in such a competitive field.

在這麼競爭激烈的領域，要成功就需要有些**拼勁和鬥志**。

MCQ-ready definition:

fire in your belly = 強烈的決心、野心或進取心

28. **fiery** (像火般的；火紅的) — 火紅的；熾熱的

Practice 1

> The sky turned a **fiery orange**.

天空變成**火紅橙色**。

Practice 2

> Lava glowed **fiery red**.

熔岩發出**火紅色**光芒。

MCQ-ready definition:

fiery = 像火一樣的，尤其指顏色、熱度或外觀

29. **fiery** (性格 / 言論猛烈的) — 火爆的；激烈的

Practice 1

> She has a **fiery temper**.

她的脾氣很**火爆**。

Practice 2

> He gave a **fiery speech**.

他發表了一場**激情而猛烈的演說**。

MCQ-ready definition:

fiery = 情緒、性格或說話非常強烈、激昂或容易發怒的

30. **fireproof — 防火的**

Practice 1

> The documents are stored in a **fireproof cabinet**.

文件存放在**防火櫃**裏。

Practice 2

> The material is designed to be **fireproof**.

這種材料被設計成**防火的**。

MCQ-ready definition:

fireproof = 能夠抵抗火焰或高溫，不容易燃燒或損壞的

31. **firefighter — 消防員**

Practice 1

> The **firefighters** arrived quickly.

消防員很快便到場。

Practice 2

> She trained to become a **firefighter**.

她接受訓練成為**消防員**。

MCQ-ready definition:

firefighter = 專門撲滅火災、救援和處理相關緊急事故的人

32. **spread like wildfire — 像野火般迅速傳開**

A major figurative expression.

Practice 1

> The rumour **spread like wildfire**.

謠言**迅速傳開**。

Practice 2

> The video **spread like wildfire** online.

影片在網上**極速瘋傳**。

MCQ-ready definition:

spread like wildfire = 非常迅速而廣泛地傳播

33. **play with fire — 玩火；冒險惹禍**

Practice 1

> Ignoring repeated warnings is **playing with fire**.

屢次忽視警告是在**玩火 / 冒險惹禍**。

Practice 2

> You're **playing with fire** if you keep missing deadlines.

如果你繼續錯過截止日期，就是在**冒險惹麻煩**。

MCQ-ready definition:

play with fire = 做非常危險、很可能帶來嚴重後果的事情

34. **add fuel to the fire — 火上加油**

Practice 1

> His comment only ****added fuel to the fire****.

他的評論只是****火上加油****。

Practice 2

> Arguing publicly would ****add fuel to the fire****.

公開爭辯只會****令情況更加惡化****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****add fuel to the fire = 令已經緊張或糟糕的情況變得更加嚴重****

35. ****out of the frying pan into the fire — 才離虎口，又入狼窩****

A fixed idiom.

Practice 1

> Changing jobs without checking the conditions could be ****out of the frying pan into the fire****.

沒有先了解條件就轉工，可能會****才離虎口，又入狼窩****。

Practice 2

> The new solution made things worse—we went ****out of the frying pan into the fire****.

新方法令情況更糟，我們簡直是****一波未平，一波又起****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****out of the frying pan into the fire = 離開一個壞處境，卻進入更糟的處境****

Important distinction 1: ****fire = flame vs fire = fire accident****

Substance/flames:

> The fire kept us warm.

火焰令我們暖和。

Incident:

> There was a fire in the building.

大樓發生火災。

Same noun, different framing.

Important distinction 2: **put out the fire vs put out fires**

Literal singular:

> put out the fire

> 滅火

Figurative plural:

> put out fires

> 不停處理突發問題

Your passage uses the second.

Important distinction 3: **put out fires vs solve problems**

solve problems

neutral and proactive or reactive.

put out fires

usually implies:

* problems have become urgent,

* you are reacting rather than planning,

* there are several problems one after another.

That nuance is crucial in your passage.

Important distinction 4: **fire someone vs lay someone off**

fire someone

usually terminate one person's employment, often because of performance or conduct.

lay someone off

usually remove a job because the company no longer needs/can support the position.

> fired for misconduct

> 因不當行為被解僱

> laid off because of budget cuts

> 因削減預算而被裁員

Important distinction 5: **fire someone vs dismiss someone**

fire

common, especially AmE and conversational English.

dismiss

more formal.

> The company fired him.

> 公司炒了他。

> He was dismissed from his post.

> 他被正式免職。

Important distinction 6: **open fire vs fire a gun**

fire a gun

perform one or more shots.

open fire

begin shooting, often repeatedly or in a conflict.

Important distinction 7: **under fire literal vs figurative**

Literal:

under gunfire.

Figurative:

under intense criticism.

The metaphor is now fully established.

Important distinction 8: **fire questions vs ask questions**

ask questions

neutral.

fire questions

very fast, forceful, repeated questioning.

It creates the image of bullets being fired one after another.

Important distinction 9: **fire off vs send**

send

neutral.

fire off

quickly send/write/say, often impulsively.

> send an email

> 發電郵

> fire off an angry email

> 迅速發出一封怒氣沖沖的電郵

Important distinction 10: **fire up literal vs figurative**

Literal/mechanical:

> fire up the engine
> 啟動引擎

Emotional:

> fire up the team
> 激發團隊鬥志

Same underlying metaphor: **ignite energy**.

Important distinction 11: **fiery vs fire**

fire

noun/verb.

fiery

adjective describing something fire-like in:

- * colour,
- * heat,
- * temper,
- * language,
- * intensity.

Important distinction 12: **fire in your belly vs angry**

Fire in your belly does not mean anger.

It usually means:

ambition + determination + drive

A person can be calm but still have plenty of fire in their belly.

Important distinction 13: **spread like wildfire**

This usually describes:

- * rumours,
- * news,
- * trends,
- * disease/information metaphorically,

emphasizing ****speed and reach****, not actual flames.

Important distinction 14: ****play with fire****

Usually metaphorical.

It means:

****knowingly take a dangerous risk****

not literally play with flames.

Important distinction 15: ****fire in your passage****

Here, ****fire**** is part of a metaphorical management expression:

****put out fires = react to urgent problems after they have already appeared****

It pairs beautifully with:

> ****planning ahead****

because the contrast is:

reactive crisis management ↔ proactive preparation

Family-extension note

****Fire**** is a very rich polysemy family. Its major modern branches include:

1. ****literal flame****

* fire

- * catch fire
- * put out a fire

2. **fire accident**

- * building fire
- * fight a fire

3. **figurative crisis**

- * put out fires

4. **weapon fire**

- * open fire
- * under fire
- * fire a gun

5. **criticism**

- * come under fire

6. **employment**

- * fire someone
- * get fired

7. **rapid verbal/digital action**

- * fire questions
- * fire off an email
- * fire back

8. **activation / motivation**

- * fire up an engine
- * fire up a team
- * fire imagination

9. **energy/personality**

- * fire in your belly
- * fiery temper

10. **idioms**

- * play with fire
- * add fuel to the fire
- * spread like wildfire

For your passage, the exact branch is:

fire = urgent problem that needs immediate reactive attention

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
-----	-----	-----	
fire (flame)	火；火焰	combustion	
fire (accident)	火災	uncontrolled burning	
catch fire	着火	begin burning	
on fire	正在燃燒	burning	
set fire to	放火燒；點燃	cause burning	
put out a fire	滅火	stop burning	
fight a fire	救火	control blaze	
fire (figurative problem)	突發危機	urgent problem	
put out fires	不停救火	reactive problem-solving	
fire (weapons)	射擊；火力	weapon discharge	
open fire	開火	begin shooting	
under fire	遭射擊 / 受批評	attack	
fire a gun	開槍	discharge weapon	
fire someone	解僱某人	employment termination	
get fired	被解僱	lose job	
firing	解僱；射擊	action	
fire questions at	連珠炮般提問	rapid questioning	
fire off	快速發出	rapid sending	
fire back	迅速回擊	quick response	
fire up	點燃；啟動	activate	
fire someone up	激發鬥志	energize	
fire imagination	激發想像力	inspire	
fire in your belly	鬥志；拼勁	determination	
fiery	火爆的；激烈的	intense	
fireproof	防火的	resist fire	
firefighter	消防員	fire response	
spread like wildfire	迅速傳開	rapid spread	
play with fire	冒險惹禍	dangerous risk	
add fuel to the fire	火上加油	worsen conflict	

For your original sentence

> Instead of constantly **putting out fires**, I started planning ahead and thinking more clearly.

Here:

putting out fires = 因為以前缺乏規劃，所以總要在問題已經變得很急時才匆忙處理

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 與其不停地**到處救火**，我開始懂得提前規劃，也能更清楚地思考。

The cleanest contrast is:

> **solve problems** = 解決問題，語氣中性

> **put out fires** = 問題一個接一個突然爆發，只能被動地緊急處理

> **plan ahead** = 提前規劃，避免問題變成危機

That **firefighting vs planning ahead** metaphor is exactly what makes the sentence vivid.